



The Mundane as Political: Alcoholic Beverage Preferences
as Signals of Political Identity in the United Kingdom

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Abstract

This dissertation examines the concept that everyday habits have come to reflect political identities. Research like this is important because it can provide insight into how polarisation and political fervour might manifest in social and/or non-political domains, providing scholars the opportunity to study these subjects through alternative dimensions, which may yield valuable and novel insights. This paper identifies alcoholic beverage preference as a potentially fruitful medium for this kind of analysis. It utilises cross-sectional survey data provided by More in Common to test whether voting intention is associated with alcoholic beverage preference. The findings suggest that while there is insufficient evidence to indicate that alcoholic beverage preferences correlate with voting intention universally, there is evidence to suggest that a preference for beverages that are culturally associated with status or tradition, such as Pimm's and gin and tonic, are positively associated with right voting intention, and negatively associated with left voting intention. It is also noted that this relationship is comparable in magnitude to that of more traditional demographic variables such as sex and education, indicating that some alcoholic beverages may possess meaningful predictive value as lifestyle-based signals of political orientation. These results, though modest, support the utility of researching lifestyle characteristics as markers of political identity and polarisation, inviting further research.

1. Introduction

In increasingly polarised societies across the globe, it is theorised that political identity has become entrenched with everyday cultural tastes (Wright, 2015), consumption habits (Stolle & Micheletti, 2013; Copeland & Boulianne, 2022; Jung & Mittal 2020), and other lifestyle cues (de Moor, 2017; Settle, 2018; Ouellet & Tremblay-Antoine, 2024). Through this entrenchment, it has been shown that some mundane and non-explicitly-political behaviours and preferences are associated with certain political dispositions (Hetherington & Weiler, 2018; Carney et al., 2008; Heisbourg, 2021). Alcoholic beverage preferences have been identified as markers of social identity and cultural taste (Brierley-Jones et al., 2014; Järvinen et al., 2014; Lennox et al., 2018), but are yet to have been studied as signals of political identity. Because alcoholic beverage preferences can reflect established correlates of political identity such as social and cultural identity, they may also signal political identity. In this sense, alcoholic beverage preference may behave as a compressed proxy of more complex sociological and economic factors associated with political identity. Given that alcoholic beverages appear to be plausible markers of political identity, an empirical inquiry into this possibility may be especially well-placed to yield a valuable contribution to the field of lifestyle-politics through identifying a new domain of political distinction. This may help scholars to understand how politics is becoming increasingly embedded in everyday life, which could have further implications for scholars interested in researching polarisation and social division. This paper aims to make this contribution by asking the following research question:

To what extent are alcoholic beverage preferences associated with voting intention in the United Kingdom?

The mechanisms that this paper presents are not necessarily unique to phenomena in the United Kingdom and should not be considered as such, although it is true that the specific beverages discussed may carry different cultural meanings elsewhere. This paper is positioned as a case study with implications for international political behaviour that utilises the United Kingdom as an empirical subject because it provides the opportunity to empirically test these mechanisms and allow inference to other national contexts that may also suffer from polarisation, not because the United Kingdom presents a universally representative account of this phenomenon. This paper's findings may therefore be treated as reasonable indicators of similar phenomena in other countries, which may present implications for scholars interested in comparative and international politics research.

The mechanisms that explain why alcoholic beverage preferences are associated with voting intention in the United Kingdom are primarily rooted in Bourdieu's (1984) theory of socially structured taste, which posits that patterns of consumption and the attribution of meaning to consumption are formed by social position and status, and Tajfel & Turner's (1979) social categorisation theory, which suggests that individuals categorise themselves and others into neat social groups to facilitate the comprehension of social complexities. Personality factors are also argued to play an important role. The expectations that these mechanisms yield form four separate hypotheses, that: right-wing voting intention is more strongly associated with (i) mass-market beverages or (ii) beverages culturally associated with status or tradition than with other beverage types; (iii) left-wing voting intention is more strongly associated with a

preference for beverages culturally coded as novel or aesthetic than with other beverage types; and (iv) the association between alcoholic beverage preference and voting intention is comparable in magnitude to some individual demographic variables.

To test these hypotheses, this paper utilises cross-sectional data from a survey by More in Common. The empirical analysis tests the relationship between stated alcoholic beverage preference, clustered by associated cultural meaning¹, and stated voting intention. These relationships are tested with a logistic regression model, controlling for demographic variables.

Chapter 2 considers the existing literature on related areas of lifestyle politics and develops the theory underpinning the hypotheses, where it concludes by outlining theoretical expectations. Chapter 3 details the research design utilised to test the hypotheses, in addition to justifying modelling decisions and considering the limitations of the design. Chapter 4 presents and interprets the model results with reference to the hypotheses. Chapter 5 finally considers the implications of these findings and the broader relevance of this paper. Overall, I show that some alcoholic beverage preferences, specifically beverages that are culturally associated with status or tradition, are associated with voting intention, while other relationships lack empirical support. This finding provides an insight into how political identity has become embedded into the features of everyday life.

¹ As implied by the theoretical framework.

2. Literature Review and Theory

2.1. The Mundane as Political

Informed by their core values, voters have been observed to discern political information from that which does not naturally or obviously transmit it, such as lifestyle cues. For instance, Settle (2018) finds that, through heightened exposure to the everyday lifestyles of others on social media, individuals subconsciously learn to politically stereotype others based on non-political behaviours such as dining or shopping habits; Ouellet & Tremblay-Antoine (2024) show that individuals are generally effective at inferring the political affiliations of others, arguing that lifestyle cues, such as type of car ownership, serve as heuristic signals for stereotype based-classification.

Interestingly, many of the assumptions that individuals make about one another appear to receive empirical support – Hetherington & Weiler (2018), for instance, find that left-leaning individuals are far more likely to drive a Toyota Prius and enjoy curries compared to right-leaning individuals who prefer pickup trucks and meatloaf; Kurnaz & Hale (2022), on the other hand, find clear associations between political leaning and TV show preferences, with those on the left preferring *Black Mirror* and those on the right preferring *Top Gear*; furthermore, Heisbourg (2021) finds clear associations between political orientation and music preferences. Hetherington & Weiler argue that these relationships between lifestyle characteristics and political orientation are explained by individuals' core values. In addition to preferring meatloaf over chicken curry, those on the right are also more likely to view the world as a threatening place and be less open to experience (Hetherington & Weiler 2018; Jost et al., 2003; De Neve, 2015; Xu et al., 2021; Ferrari & Smith, 2025). It is intuitively

plausible that an enhanced sensitivity to threat may align with a preference for a large, loud, and durable pickup truck compared to, say, a smaller, less boxy, electric or hybrid car like a Toyota Prius. Similarly, in the case of US citizens, it follows that a proclivity towards the well-worn over the new may coincide with an aversion to food from ‘exotic’ cuisines, and instead a preference for more home-grown American staples like meatloaf.

To understand the mechanisms that underlie the stereotype-based categorisation that these scholars have observed, I utilise social categorisation theory, pioneered by Tajfel & Turner (1979). Social categorisation theory provides several useful frameworks that, incidentally, work to explain the mechanisms involved in producing this phenomenon. Tajfel & Turner argue that we categorise people into groups in order to simplify and facilitate understanding of the complex world around us. For instance, the descriptive categories of ‘punk’ or ‘skater’ evoke images of people who dress and behave in specific ways (Trepte, 2006); it is natural, therefore, for human beings to automatically categorise other people into the groups that correspond with their appearance or behaviours. In this sense, social categorisations are ‘cognitive tools that segment, classify, and order the social environment, and thus enable the individual to undertake many forms of social action’ (Tajfel & Turner, 1979, p. 40). Of course, *self-categorisation* is, in many cases, a tautological prerequisite for the categorisation of others. We often self categorise as fans of specific sports, or genres of music, for example; we may then adhere to a certain style of dress or lexicon that we feel in some way communicates our membership of this category to others. It is noted that the formation of social identity in this manner is contingent upon the salience of the group membership in question – that is, the context-dependent activation of a particular social identity. For instance, in a domestic context, one may perceive themselves and those around them as being, in that moment, predominantly members of the household. However, in the context of

the workplace, for example, this perception may shift, with both internal and external social categorisation occurring along the lines of professional role or position. Applied to Hetherington & Weiler's domain of vehicle preference, the proposed self-categorisation mechanism involved can be schematically represented as follows:

an individual enacts upon a preference for pickup trucks → the cue of pickup truck activates a social category to which the individual perceives themselves as belonging → this category becomes salient → the individual perceives themselves less as a unique person and more as a member of this group → the norms and prototypes of this group are internalised → the individual aligns their attitudes and behaviours, which includes political inclinations, with those perceived to be quintessential of the group.

Of course, a preference for pickup trucks does not *cause* an individual to express conservative values, but it may be the case that once the 'pickup truck owner' category is salient for the self, latent conservatism becomes more normatively congruent and thus easier to express. A pickup truck owner may possess many different attitudes, held with varying convictions. Once the identity of 'pickup truck owner' becomes salient, the attitudes that the individual associates with this group become stronger than those perceived as less associated. In this sense, salience functions as an attitudinal filter, rather than a generator.

Other similar work has attempted to establish a relationship between the ownership of various household items and political beliefs. Carney et al. (2008), for instance, report that ownership of world music CDs and art supplies strongly predicts liberal politics, whereas ownership of sports related decor and event calendars tends to predict conservative beliefs. Indeed, many of these objects were shown to far exceed more classical predictors of political orientation

such as age or education level. Carney et al. argue that these relationships exist because they both correlate with personality factors. Individuals who are very open to experience tend to feel attracted towards the creative arts and the unfamiliar, leading to an interest in art and world music. Openness to experience is also shown to be associated with left-wing political beliefs – these individuals are excited by differences and generally more trusting of others, therefore, for them, it would be unnecessary or cruel to administer stringent controls on immigration or legislate against LGBT rights. Because both of these characteristics are strongly linked with the same variable, they can, as covariates, be used to predict each other. It is this mechanism that enables Carney et al. to infer an individual's political leaning by their ownership of seemingly entirely mundane objects.

From these frameworks it follows that an individual's lifestyle preferences, influenced by a myriad of factors including demographic background (Bourdieu, 1984), core values, and personality may function as a signal of political orientation, a synthesis of more downstream, fundamental and classical factors that are known to associate with political orientation. In recent years, it has been argued that class may now be a less robust and straightforward indicator of political affiliation than it was prior to the twenty-first century (Evans & Tilley, 2017), with other cleavages such as national identity perhaps overriding the traditional class-based voting calculus. The recent rise of radical right parties, for instance, makes a great case study for this shift (see Marchesi, 2022; Ramaekers et al., 2023; Im et al., 2023). In light of this dynamism, the study of lifestyle cleavages may help to provide some stability in measurement and group differentiation to scholars interested in understanding public attitudes in the modern age.

2.2. Alcoholic Beverages as Forms of Expression

In his seminal work, *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgement of Taste*, Bourdieu theorises that ‘consumption...is a stage in the process of communication’ (1984, p. 2). Individuals attribute meaning to that which they consume, and vice versa, the nature of the meaning that is attributed also signals something about their own structural position in society, thus, ‘taste classifies, and it classifies the classifier’ (p. 6). In Bourdieu’s survey work, he finds a clear relationship between one’s structural position and mode of taste; for instance, the less educated and those working in blue-collar occupations have a tendency to form in favour of function, while the opposite is true for those who possess large volumes of cultural capital. It is this mechanism that determines how individuals tend to engage with their surroundings. Engagement with art, in particular, is perhaps the most immediately obvious domain over which this mechanism dictates. For Bourdieu, individuals who possess smaller volumes of cultural capital (i.e., the working class) are more likely to expect artistic mediums as vehicles to allow them to ‘believe naively in the things represented’, whereas their upper class counterparts ‘could be said to believe in the representation – literature, theatre, painting – more than in the things represented’ (p. 5). Indeed, Bourdieu provides empirical support for these theoretical propositions with his survey work.

While art and similar cultural domains lend themselves to being theatres for this bi-directional distinction, Bourdieu stresses that ‘there is no area of practice in which the aim of purifying, refining, and sublimating primary needs and impulses cannot assert itself, no area in which the stylisation of life, that is, the primacy of forms over function, of manner over matter, does not produce the same effects’ (p. 5). If, as argued, the aesthetic disposition

can inundate any practical domain, it may be that alcoholic beverages operate as such a field of stylisation and distinction in the United Kingdom.

A study of alcoholic beverages, specifically, as a medium for distinction and ideological communication is apt for various reasons. Previous work has already established the consumption of alcoholic beverages as a means of distinction (Brierley-Jones et al., 2014; Järvinen et al., 2014; Lennox et al., 2018), eliminating the need for a novel philosophical inquiry aimed at establishing the theoretical support required to justify the purpose and productivity of further research. For instance, Järvinen et al. (2014) show that drinking styles and alcohol preferences are associated with specific positions in the status structures of some workplaces. High status positions, corresponding to managerial roles with high salaries, are most associated with taste-oriented consumption, often preferring wines and cocktails. Lower status positions, however, are associated with drinking to ‘ease social relations’ (p. 399), and a preference for strong beer, expressing an avoidance of wine. Järvinen et al. argue, for high status individuals, beverage consumption operates as a symbol of social status, particularly in networking contexts, where it is often leveraged for professional gain. This indicates that alcoholic beverages can behave as patterned conduits for the expression of cultural capital.

While drinking has been studied as a means of social distinction, it is yet to be studied as a medium for political expression – precluding potentially interesting and useful contributions to relevant fields of research. Bourdieu allows for the interpretation of how social structure relates to alcohol preferences, but not how alcohol preferences relate to political orientation. To accomplish this, Bourdieu must be combined with social categorisation theory, which provides the link between taste and political values via the mechanism presented in the previous section. Because quantitative research designs have yielded valuable results in

analogous lifestyle politics domains, and given that alcoholic drinks have been shown to satisfy the same theoretical criteria of socially structured taste as many of these previously and fruitfully studied domains², it is reasonable to expect that a study of alcoholic drinks is especially well-positioned to produce findings that are comparable in value.

In their 75 year chronology of studies regarding the influences of culture on alcohol use, Castro et al. (2014) show that norms around alcohol consumption vary significantly between different cultural groups. In many cultures, consumption tends to be permissive or even celebrated for men and very restrictive for women. Moreover, consumption is often accepted in structured contexts such as in social and ritualistic settings and stigmatised outside of these environments. Fundamentally, the influence that cultural norms are shown to have over alcohol consumption implies that culture may also possess the capacity to establish specific drink types as transmitters of varying social meaning. This framework assumes that if norms structure *how* people drink, they can also structure *what* they drink. Indeed, Brierley-Jones et al. (2014)'s qualitative study of class-based drinking habits found that wine consumption was associated with a wealthy, cosmopolitan 'home-drinking' habitus, whereas beer, lager, and spirits were linked with a more traditional and working class habitus. In Bourdieuan terms, wine appears to behave as a symbol of distinction from more 'common' modes of alcohol consumption. This supports the conclusion that beverage types map onto different class-lifestyle identities. Moreover, consumer research finds that beverage preferences tend to be patterned according to age, gender, and taste responsiveness (Cravero et al., 2020), while other research goes further to explicitly associate beer, spirits, and wine with voting behaviour by geographic region (Yakovlev & Guessford, 2013). These findings further sustain the proposition that these choices are not random.

² Musical preference, for instance (Bourdieu, 1984; Heisbourg, 2021).

2.3. Cleavages of the British Political Right and Left

In advance of testing the relationships between types of voting intention and beverage preferences, it is important to determine the extent to which the left and right are internally culturally homogenous. It is useful to understand these nuances such that they can be reflected in the hypotheses, more closely resembling reality.

For most of British political history, the Conservative Party has been the dominant right-wing political party (Evans & Tilley, 2017). The most recent Conservative Party governments have leaned towards either a One Nation or New Right ethos in their administration. After the 2016 European Union membership referendum, right-wing populism, which emphasises the notion of a virtuous common people in opposition to a perceived malicious or out-of-touch elite (Mudde, 2004), quickly emerged as a mainstream form of political orientation (Griffiths et al., 2026), with the populist Reform UK a mainstream party today.

In the 2019 general election, under the influence of Boris Johnson's more populist brand of conservatism, large segments of the Labour Party's traditional working class and trade unionist support base voted for the Conservative Party (Furlong, 2019), an act of political realignment along the lines of culture and identity (Hobolt et al., 2021; Griffiths et al., 2026). The post-2016 right has been shown to include both populist, anti-elite voters associated with membership of lower social classes³, and establishment, status-oriented voters associated with membership of the more traditional middle and upper class Conservative Party support

³ Identified by the NatCen Social Research (2023) as the 'Left-Behind Patriots'.

base⁴ (Cutts et al., 2020; Evans & Langsæther, 2021; NatCen Social Research, 2023). While these two groups both advocate for right-wing politics, their cultures and experiences differ greatly. From Bourdieu, it would follow that upper class, establishment voters are more likely to favour form over function, whereas lower class populist voters are, conversely, inclined to subordinate form in favour of function (Bourdieu, 1984). Subsequently, it is likely that in spite of exhibiting similar voting behaviours, these two groups are likely to disagree on matters of taste, warranting their consideration as two separate groups. In this sense, it may be that beverage preferences not only behave as a marker of distinction between the political left and right, but they may also distinguish between *types* of right-wing voters too.

There is limited evidence to suggest that a cleavage of similar proportions exists in the British left, however. Research by the NatCen Social Research (2023) suggests that the left may be primarily divided by perspectives on economic issues, with one group expressing more centrist views on the economy than the other. Notwithstanding this small ideological discrepancy, these two groups remain demographically very similar – highly likely to vote, university educated, and financially comfortable (NatCen Social Research, 2023) – indicating that their tastes may be much more homogenous than those of right-wing voters who are much more divided by class.

2.4. Theoretical Expectations and Hypotheses

Bourdieu's work suggests that socioeconomic configuration produces taste, which becomes tied to social and cultural identity. When taste becomes connected to identity, it has the capacity to become salient, influencing self-alignment with the political attitudes of the

⁴ Identified by the NatCen Social Research (2023) as the 'Well-Off Traditionalists'.

cultural group. Indeed because alcohol consumption is ritualised, conversational, and often context dependent, it is particularly well-suited to signal identity. Some right-wing voters, particularly those who value homogeneity and function, such as populist voters, may favour mass-market beverages such as lager. Because they are designed for long-term mass-appeal, mass-market beverages tend to be unambiguous, standardised, and broadly inoffensive in flavour and character. Other right-wing voters, particularly those who value status, such as establishment voters, may favour beverages associated with social rank such as Pimm's – a beverage associated with upper class social events such as The Henley Royal Regatta, Wimbledon, and the Chelsea Flower Show – or gin and tonic – associated with gentleman's clubs⁵, James Bond, and British colonial forces.

Equally, it may be reasonable to expect that left-wing preferences for novelty and creativity or cultural expression may be associated with preferences for beverages associated with aestheticisation and complexity such as wine or cocktails. Both wine and cocktails are frequently conceived of as vessels of flavour, character, and experience requiring highly specialised labour to produce, which also ensures they are consistently sold at premium prices. Attributing value to the character of a beverage, such as the origin and vintage of a wine, or the balance and composition of a cocktail, demands comfort with abstract thought and openness to experience – both of which are close correlates of left-wing political belief. The heterogeneity within the right suggests that right-wing taste cannot be fully captured by a single category of beverage consumption. Instead, it is necessary to consider the taste preferences of both cleavages as analytically separate predictors, to ensure that this heterogeneity is accounted for. While it is yet to have been examined by the literature empirically, this theoretical chain would support the claims that:

⁵ See Hands (2018).

H1: Right-wing voting intention is more strongly associated with mass-market beverages than with beverages culturally coded as novel or aesthetic;

H2: Right-wing voting intention is more strongly associated with beverages culturally coded as traditional or of high social status than with beverages culturally coded as novel or aesthetic;

H3: Left-wing voting intention is more strongly associated with a preference for beverages culturally coded as novel or aesthetic than with mass-market or traditional and status-coded beverages.

While not implied by Bourdieu, methodological and social science research suggests that traditional demographic proxies of political orientation are most useful when used in combination because it allows for the construction of better-informed and potentially more accurate profiles (NatCen Social Research, 2023). Alcoholic beverage preference is theorised to behave as a compressed proxy of multiple traditional variables and personality factors combined. This is to say that, because preference appears to be related with class and status, which are themselves products of more micro-level factors such as education, finances, and occupation, it may follow that an individual's beverage preference combines and retains the predictive value of these factors as a single variable. If this is the case, it should be empirically verifiable that:

H4: The association between alcoholic beverage preference and voting intention is comparable in magnitude to some individual demographic variables.

3. Research Design

3.1. Data Source and Sample Characteristics

To test the hypotheses, this paper utilises a cross-sectional dataset⁶ containing individual-level responses to a survey written and coded by polling and market research group, More in Common, with fieldwork conducted by a third party panel. The surveyed respondents are selected through demographic quotas based on age interlocked with sex, university education, and census region, approximating characteristics of the wider UK population. The data were collected following the 2024 UK General Election.

*Table 1*⁷ presents basic demographics for the full sample, which totals 2,073 respondents. The sample population appears comparable with the wider UK population. This congruency is advantageous because it suggests that any findings derived from the sample may broadly reflect phenomena present in the wider population. However, because the sample is derived from a quota as opposed to a random probability sample, selection into the dataset is not random and may introduce bias. As such, findings cannot be assumed to fully generalise to the wider UK population without caution.

⁶ The dataset is unpublished and not publicly accessible. It is therefore not included in the reference list.

⁷ Response categories for Education, Personal Income, Region, and Work Status have been aggregated and renamed for brevity. See appendix *Table B1* for full and unedited demographic data.

Table 1: Sample Demographics

		N	Percent
Gender	Female	1081	52.15
	Male	992	47.85
Education	Postgraduate	272	13.12
	Prefer not to answer	11	0.53
	Secondary or Below	916	44.19
	Undergraduate	460	22.19
	Vocational	414	19.97
Personal Income	Don't know	101	4.87
	High (£50,000 to £100,000 or More)	436	21.03
	Low (No Annual Income to £29,999)	1050	50.65
	Middle (£30,000 to £49,999)	486	23.44
Region	Midlands	327	15.77
	North England	504	24.31
	Scotland	146	7.04
	South England	995	48.00
	Wales	101	4.87
Work Status	Employed	1242	59.91
	Inactive	93	4.49
	Prefer not to say	19	0.92
	Retired	487	23.49
	Student	80	3.86
	Unemployed	152	7.33

Notes: Age (Mean = 48.70, SD = 17.85) is reported separately from the table due to data type conflicts.

While the variance between response categories is largely normal and expected, to preserve inference, it will be important to control for it in the empirical analysis to help ensure that the relationship being estimated mirrors the relationships specified by the hypotheses rather than products of confounding.

3.2. Dependent Variable

To measure voting intention, I use clustered voting intention. This is a categorical variable that records respondents' voting intentions by broad political orientation (e.g., right, left, centre).

Table 2: Descriptive Statistics on Clustered Voting Intention

Clustered Voting Intention	N	Percent
Another party/Independent candidate	16	0.77
Centre	235	11.34
Don't know	220	10.61
I would not vote	162	7.81
Left	641	30.92
Right	799	38.54

Notes:

'Right' = Conservative, Reform UK;

'Left' = Labour, Scottish National Party (SNP), Plaid Cymru, The Green Party;

'Centre' = Liberal Democrats.

Table 2 shows the distribution of respondents by their clustered voting intention. These clusters ensure that left-wing and right-wing voting intention is featured frequently across the dataset and that these categories are sufficient enough in number so as to be able to produce meaningful results. Clustered voting intention is selected for the dependent variable instead

of unclustered voting intention for two reasons. Clustered voting intention, which groups respondents by the general political orientation of the party that they express an intent to vote for, (i) better aligns with the hypotheses, which specify broad orientation, such as left and right, rather than support for individual parties, and (ii) increases statistical power by combining low cell-count party-level categories together. Voting intention, from which clustered voting intention is derived, is a categorical variable that records respondents' answers to the question 'If a general election was called tomorrow, which party would you vote for?'. The survey question is multiple choice with 10 answer options.

Table 2 indicates that right and left voting intention is fairly evenly split in the sample, with right voting slightly more prevalent than left voting. The other clusters are, comparatively, much smaller than the left and right clusters. Only the left and right clusters, however, operationalise the dependent variable in modelling. This is because the other clusters are not specified by the hypotheses.

3.3. Independent Variable

To measure alcoholic beverage preference, I use clustered beverage preference. This is a categorical variable that records respondents' beverage preferences, grouped by how they might be culturally coded (e.g., mass market, aesthetic, status-traditional).

Beverage preferences are clustered because the hypotheses refer to broader forms of culturally coded taste rather than beverages as individual items. The theoretical argument in the previous chapter asserts that beverage preferences may signal taste, which may correlate with political orientation. Therefore, clustering beverages by the style of taste that they may

represent corresponds more closely to the subject under investigation than if they were treated individually. The mass-market cluster comprises cider and lager. These beverages are highly accessible, unseasonal, standardised, and tend to be associated with routine drinking contexts rather than as mediums of stylised form. The aesthetic cluster comprises aperol spritz, frozen margarita, daiquiri, and rosé wine. The nature of these beverages plausibly communicate novelty, presentation, flavour, and experience. These associations suggest that their consumption may not be a product of non-stylised, functional tastes, but instead more appreciative and intentional. The status-traditional cluster comprises Pimm's and gin and tonic. The prestigious events that these beverages are usually served at, such as the Henley Royal Regatta and Wimbledon suggests they may be culturally associated with Britishness and status. While the construction of these clusters is a necessarily interpretivist undertaking, they enable a theory-led operationalisation of the mechanisms developed in the previous chapter.

Table 3: Descriptive Statistics on Clustered Beverage Preference

Clustered Beverage Preference	N	Percent
Aesthetic	497	23.97
Mass Market	573	27.64
Non Drinker	392	18.91
None of the above	288	13.89
Status Traditional	323	15.58

Notes:

'Aesthetic' = aperol spritz, frozen margarita, daiquiri, rose wine;

'Mass Market' = cider, lager;

'Status Traditional' = gin and tonic, Pimm's.

Table 3 indicates that, predictably, mass-market beverages are the most popular among the sample. This is closely followed by aesthetic beverages, with the more niche and more specialised status-traditional beverages as the least popular. There are also a considerable number of non drinkers and respondents who indicated a preference outside of the beverage types provided in the survey. This distribution is also consistent with market research on alcohol consumption. YouGov (2024) finds that lager is the United Kingdom's most popular beverage, while gin is preferred by only 7% of the population. This lends support to the above argument that lager and beverages such as cider are characterised by mass appeal, while gin and tonic is perhaps more niche and reflects a more specialised taste.

Although clustering improves our capacity to adequately test the hypotheses with statistical methods, it should be noted that it necessarily obscures the detection of potentially interesting phenomena internal to these groups – differences between Labour and Green voters, for instance – incurring the loss of more granular relationships.

3.4. Empirical Strategy and Models

Given the observational nature of the data, this research design is only able to find associations between variables, rather than identify causal effects. Furthermore, while the control variables adjust for any confounding effects presented by observed variables, unobserved variables are still likely to influence the phenomena recorded in the dataset, and therefore the results of this research. Accordingly, it is important that the findings are interpreted as solely correlational. Moreover, as stated by the theoretical framework, this design is not interested in finding causal effects. This paper fundamentally seeks to test the utility of alcoholic beverage preferences as signals, not causes, of political identity.

To robustly estimate the statistical relationships between alcoholic beverage preferences and voting intention, as required by the hypotheses, it is necessary to employ a modelling strategy. In all four of the hypotheses, voting intention is the dependent variable (DV) and alcoholic beverage preference is the independent variable (IV), where the unit of analysis is individual survey respondents. Both the DV and the IV are categorical variables indicating whether a respondent belongs to a given cluster, where membership is mutually exclusive. For instance, a respondent may belong to the right-voting cluster and therefore not another cluster. A respondent cannot, however, belong to both the right-voting cluster and the 'Would not vote' cluster simultaneously. Because the hypotheses describe relationships between specific clusters within the DV and IV, I further operationalise these variables as binary indicators of membership to a given cluster, such that each cluster is treated as its own variable whereby membership is true or false. These relationships must also be compared with one another, as well as quantified.

Given the nature of the DV as a binary variable, it is important to select a model that is effective at modelling binary variables. Logistic regression, which models the probability of a given binary outcome, is a common method for estimating the relationship between variables where the DV is binary (Hosmer et al., 2013; Wooldridge, 2010; Long & Freese, 2006). This is a suitable method with which to test the hypotheses because cluster membership is a binary variable. Moreover, the hypotheses specify membership rather than magnitude. While other models, such as OLS regression, may be effective to indicate ideological position on a continuous scale, the selected DV indicates binary cluster membership, making it unsuitable for this research. Therefore, methods that model magnitude and not membership are unsuited to this research. Logistic regression is also capable of parsing mixed variable types, meaning

that it is possible to control for both continuous variables, such as age, and categorical variables, such as region, handled through dummy variables in R. Given that the hypotheses refer to specific clusters, a multinomial regression, which is capable of predicting membership of multiple clusters at once, is unnecessary and would likely hinder interpretability. For these reasons, logistic regression is selected to test the hypotheses.

The estimated coefficients produced by the logistic regression reflect the change in the log-odds of membership to the given ideological cluster based on membership to the given beverage cluster.

The outcomes of the hypotheses are decided by interpretation of these results. In particular, statistically significant ($p < 0.05$) and directionally consistent coefficients of sufficient magnitudes that remain stable across both the baseline and full controls model would indicate the existence of a positive relationship between the dependent and independent variables, providing sufficient evidence to reject the null hypothesis. Effect magnitudes are interpreted in relation to traditional predictors of voting intention such as age and education. In the event that the model coefficients are reported as non-significant ($p > 0.05$), the null hypothesis fails to be rejected. The models are also tested for goodness-of-fit to further test the validity of their results.

Logistic regression models are estimated using R's *glm* function from the base *stats* package (see R Core Team, 2024) in RStudio (Posit team, 2026). Models are specified as binomial logits, which are generalised linear models adapted to accommodate a binary dependent variable using a binomial error distribution and a logit link function. Full baseline and control model specifications are included in appendix C.

3.5. Controls

Associates of voting intention, as shown by the literature, are selected as control variables. This strategy helps to ensure that the associations between beverage preference and voting intention are isolated from confounding variables. As stated previously, however, it is impossible to account for confounding fully. The association between class⁸ and voting intention is very well supported by the literature (see Jerrim & Kaye, 2025; Kulachai et al., 2023; Lipset, 1959; Inglehart, 1977), with relationships discovered between left-wing voting intention and membership of the middle class, while right-wing voting appears to be linked to more working class backgrounds (Evans & Tilley, 2017). Age is another particularly well supported predictor of both turnout and voting intention (Franklin, 2004). Younger voters, perhaps due to being less economically secure, consistently tend to vote for left-wing parties, while wealthier older voters, who tend to favour low taxation and property rights, often vote for right-wing parties (Sturgis & Jennings, 2020; Butler & Stokes, 1971; Clarke et al., 2016).

Gender is another reliable indicator of voting intention (Inglehart & Norris, 2000; Studlar et al., 1998). Women have been shown to generally favour left-wing parties over right-wing parties (Shorrocks, 2018). Men, however, are generally more likely to vote for more right-wing parties (Shorrocks, 2018). These effects tend to be small, however, and not universal.

Region also has a well documented influence on voting intention. Voters in northern England, for instance, have been shown to vote differently than voters in southern England (Johnston

⁸ Operationalised through the *personalincome*, *education*, *finances*, *workstatus*, and *housingtenure* variables.

& Pattie, 1989; Horan et al., 2024). Cutts et al. (2023) explain this phenomena as an artefact of differences in regional cultures around voting and politics. For similar reasons, such as exposure to globalisation (Lago & Lago-Peñas, 2025) or differing levels of openness to experience (Hummler & Ziller, 2025), voters in urban areas also tend to vote differently to voters in rural areas (Claassen et al., 2025). This is also linked to ethnicity, another core demographic variable that has been shown to predict voting intention (Ipsos, 2024).

4. Results

4.1. Right Voting Intention

Table 4 reports results for all models where right voting is the DV.

Table 4: Logistic Regression Models Predicting Right Voting

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Right voting intention					
	M1	M1 Control	M2	M2 Control	M3	M3 Control
MassMarket	0.193*	0.091				
	(0.100)	(0.112)				
StatusTraditional			0.460***	0.453***		
			(0.122)	(0.132)		
Aesthetic					-0.176	0.058
					(0.107)	(0.120)
McFadden pseudo R ²	0.001	0.079	0.005	0.083	0.001	0.079
Observations	2,073	2,073	2,073	2,073	2,073	2,073
Log Likelihood	-1,380.132	-1,272.483	-1,374.920	-1,266.989	-1,380.625	-1,272.695
Akaike Inf. Crit.	2,764.265	2,664.967	2,753.839	2,653.979	2,765.250	2,665.390

Note:

* p<0.1; ** p<0.05; *** p<0.01

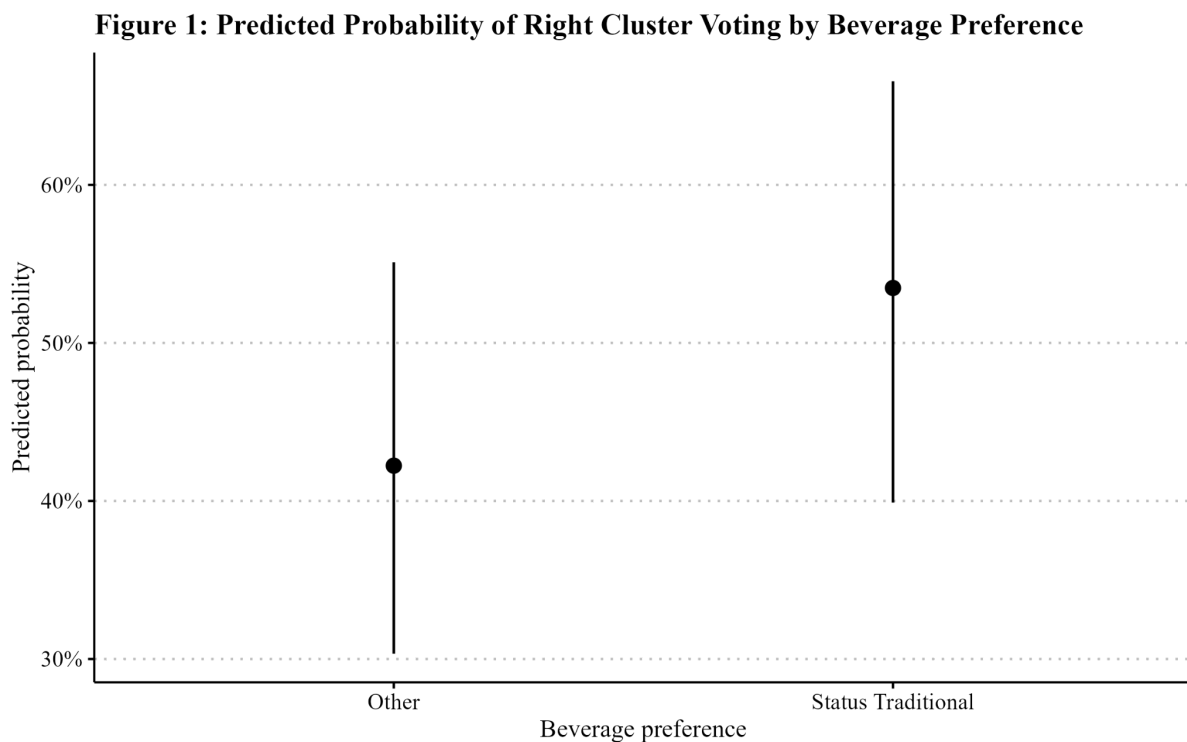
Table shows coefficients with standard errors in parentheses.
Controls omitted for brevity (for full table see appendix).

A preference for status-traditional beverages is positively associated with right-voting intention. Preferences for mass-market beverages and aesthetic beverages, however, are not associated with right voting intention. These results are consistent with H2 given that there appears to be a positive and statistically significant relationship between a preference for beverages coded as status-traditional and right voting intention, while there is no evidence of a relationship between a preference for beverages coded as aesthetic and right voting intention. While M1 reports some significance for the relationship between a preference for mass-market beverages and right voting intention, this significance is lost in the controls model, suggesting that this effect may instead be the product of demographic and social factors. These results therefore do not support H1.

Overall, M2 Control improves prediction of the distribution in right voting by approximately 8.3% (McFadden pseudo $R^2 = 0.083$) relative to an intercept-only model with no predictors, reflecting a modest advantage over a null model. This is expected and consistent with models of survey behaviour, where responses are influenced by highly complex and numerous observed and unobserved factors.

The regression coefficient for the association between a preference for status-traditional beverages and right voting is reported by M2 as 0.460 ($p < 0.01$). Exponentiated, this coefficient gives an odds ratio of approximately 1.58. This odds ratio is reduced slightly to 1.57 by the controls model. This indicates that a preference for status-traditional beverages is associated with 57% higher odds of right-wing voting intention relative to other beverage categories.

Figure 1 shows the predicted probability of right voting intention by beverage preference. M2 Control gives a predicted probability of 53% for respondents who prefer status-traditional beverages. This is compared with a predicted probability of 42% amongst those who prefer other types of beverages. A preference for status-traditional beverages is therefore associated with an 11.3 percentage point increase in the probability of right voting intention.



For comparison, the odds ratio given by M2 Control for the relationship between being male and right voting intention is approximately 1.25 ($p < 0.05$), meaning that the model finds a stronger relationship between a preference for status-traditional beverages and right voting intention than it does for sex and right voting. Moreover, the magnitude of the association between status-traditional beverage preference and right voting intention is greater than those reported for each education-related dummy variable, suggesting that, within this specification, its association with right voting intention is comparably meaningful. I therefore

reject the null hypothesis for H2 that right voting intention is not more strongly associated with beverages culturally coded as traditional or high social status than with beverages culturally coded as novel or aesthetic.

Given that results for mass-market beverage preference are not statistically significant, I fail to reject the null hypothesis for H1 that right voting intention is not more strongly associated with mass-market beverages than with beverages culturally coded as novel or aesthetic.

4.2. Left Voting Intention

Table 5 reports results for all models where left voting is the DV. Although M6 does report a significant relationship between a preference for aesthetic beverages and left voting intention, as anticipated by H3, the significance of this association vanishes when controls are introduced, suggesting that the reported relationship is likely merely an artefact of covariation. I therefore fail to reject the H3 null hypothesis that left voting intention is not more strongly associated with a preference for beverages culturally coded as aesthetic. There appears to be a statistically significant negative relationship between left voting intention and status-traditional beverage preferences. This finding shows an inverse of H2, whereby a preference for status-traditional beverages is negatively associated with left voting intention, therefore further supporting H2.

Table 5: Logistic Regression Models Predicting Left Voting

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Left voting intention					
	M4	M4 Control	M5	M5 Control	M6	M6 Control
MassMarket	-0.105 (0.107)	-0.153 (0.121)				
StatusTraditional			-0.458*** (0.141)	-0.341** (0.153)		
Aesthetic					0.457*** (0.108)	0.146 (0.123)
McFadden pseudo R ²	0	0.105	0.004	0.106	0.007	0.105
Observations	2,073	2,073	2,073	2,073	2,073	2,073
Log Likelihood	-1,281.610	-1,147.662	-1,276.537	-1,145.905	-1,273.227	-1,147.764
Akaike Inf. Crit.	2,567.220	2,415.323	2,557.074	2,411.811	2,550.455	2,415.528

Note:

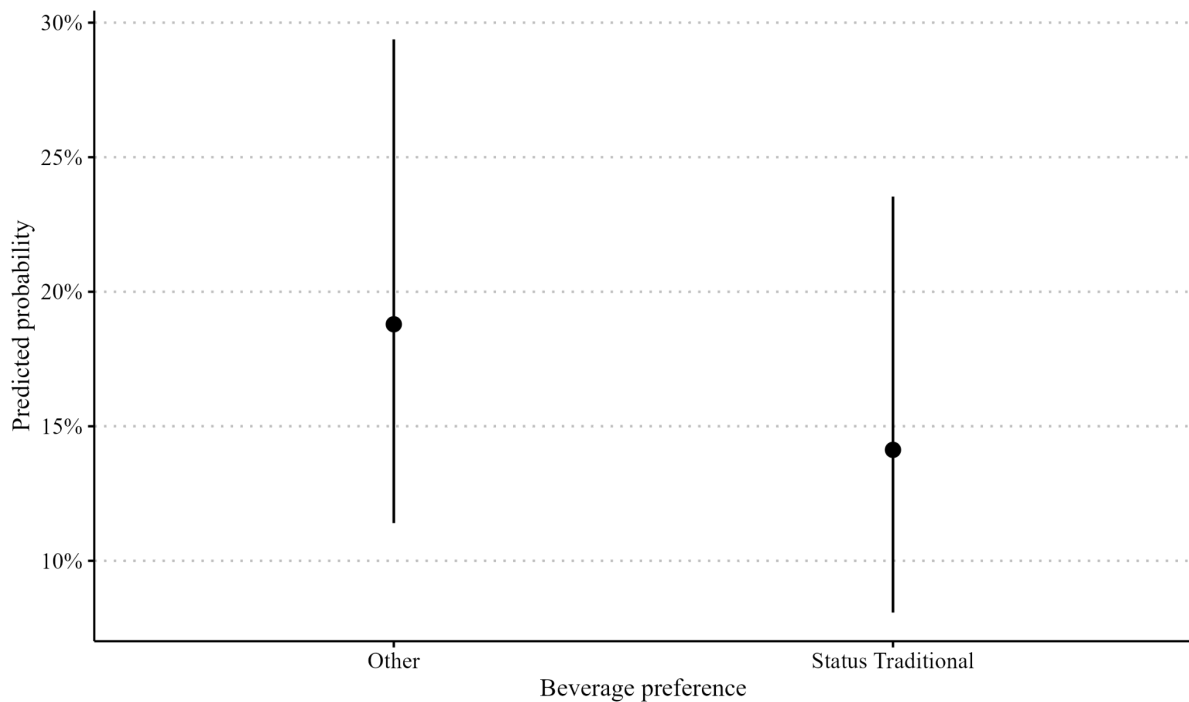
*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table shows coefficients with standard errors in parentheses.
Controls omitted for brevity (for full table see appendix).

M5 Control appears to improve fit by approximately 10.6% relative to a null model (McFadden pseudo R² = 0.106), reflecting a still modest, but slightly superior fit to M2 Control. This result is also expected given the nature of the data.

Figure 2 shows the predicted probability of left voting intention by beverage preference. M5 Control gives a predicted probability of 14% for respondents who prefer status-traditional beverages, and a predicted probability of 19% for those who prefer other beverages. This suggests that respondents who favour status-traditional beverages are 5 percentage points less likely to express a left-wing voting intention.

Figure 2: Predicted Probability of Left Voting Intention by Beverage Preference



While there is evidence that the magnitude of the association between a preference for status-traditional beverages and right voting intention is comparable to some demographic variables, this finding does not hold true for other beverage types. For this reason, I only find partial support for H4.

4.3. Robustness

As a robustness check, I run models where beverage preference is unclustered. These relationships disappear when tested with this configuration⁹. This suggests that evidence is stronger at the taste-category level rather than on the individual beverage level. This is unsurprising, given that, on the individual level, many beverage preference categories have small cell counts which limits statistical power.

⁹ See appendix for regression tables.

4.4. Limitations

While this research design is capable of testing the hypotheses developed in the previous chapter, it is nonetheless limited by several data and methodological constraints that compromise its ability to test the theory more completely and effectively. Perhaps most significantly, the beverage preference variable from which the independent variable is derived only allowed respondents to indicate a preference for one of eight pre-selected beverages. For instance, respondents were not permitted to indicate a preference for stout or red wine, but they were permitted to indicate a preference for frozen margarita or Pimm's. In particular, beverage types such as craft beer may have been a particularly useful point of analysis as a stylised variety of a more traditionally mass-market beverage. In this sense, the inclusion of craft beer may have enabled a more direct analysis of the effect of stylisation on associated voting intention than is possible with the available data, potentially precluding richer findings.

Another consequence of this limited range is that many respondents (288) indicated a preference for none of the beverages available as preference options. While these respondents represent a minority of the sample, it might have been that a broader array of beverage options may have facilitated additional, more useful points of analysis than is otherwise available.

Moreover, it is important to recognise that the beverage preference variable only measures stated preference and not actual consumption. Although this is useful for analysing beverages as conduits of identity, because respondents may have indicated their preference partially on the grounds of symbolic meaning, it means that the analysis cannot establish whether

respondents actually regularly consume their preferred beverage. For instance, an individual may value status and respectability, therefore indicating a preference for Pimm's, but actually consume lager far more regularly. This means that positive findings cannot necessarily be interpreted as a novel means to identify political affiliation through merely the consumption of a beverage. Future research might, however, resolve this limitation by distinguishing between consumption and stated preference with a more specialised survey design.

Similarly, the survey required that respondents choose a preference for only one beverage instead of rank multiple according to preference. This necessarily precludes the discovery of more complex, nuanced relationships as well as additional confidence. For instance, it may be that an individual who has expressed a preference for lager, a mass-market beverage, may secondarily prefer frozen margarita, an aesthetic beverage. If these relationships could be explored, it might increase the likelihood of finding that beverage preference has no significant relationship with voting intention. Alternatively, if a pattern emerged where those who indicated mass-market beverages as favourites tended to indicate aesthetic beverages as least favourites, this may provide additional support to reject the null hypotheses and conclude that beverage preference indeed does have a significant relationship with voting intention.

As a result of statistical power concerns, this paper has not considered centre voting in its analysis. This decision, while motivated by sound reasoning, may have precluded valuable findings, thereby risking the loss of additional nuance with which to approach evaluating the hypotheses. An emphasis on centre politics should be considered in future work through a more purpose-built survey.

Because the data is cross-sectional, in the event that significant relationships do exist, it is not possible to establish whether they are stable features of social phenomena, or merely artefacts of the period during which the data was collected. This is an especially pertinent consideration given that the 2024 General Election was somewhat anomalous compared with previous elections due to the success of Reform UK and the collapse of the Conservative vote.

5. Conclusion

Political identity and voting intention are traditionally understood through the study of explicitly political behaviour. Other scholars, such as Bourdieu, Carney et al., and Hetherington & Weiler, in particular, have laid the theoretical and empirical groundwork to suggest that broader lifestyle factors and non-explicitly political correlates of taste could behave similarly. Previous work has identified alcoholic beverages as a domain for taste-based social distinction, but has yet to consider them as plausible signals of political behaviour. This paper has sought to address this gap by examining whether alcoholic beverage preferences are associated with political voting intention in the United Kingdom. Specifically, I examined the roles of social categorisation theory, personality, and the judgement of taste as composites of a plausible mechanism to assert the existence of a meaningful relationship between alcoholic beverage preference and voting intention. Through an empirical analysis, I find that alcoholic beverages culturally coded as mass-market and aesthetic are not significantly related to voting intention. However, I also find that beverages culturally coded as markers of status or tradition are significantly related to both right- and left-voting intention, whereby individuals who state a preference for such beverages are 11.3

percentage points more likely to indicate a right-wing voting intention than individuals who state a preference for other beverage types. Equally, these individuals are also 5 percentage points less likely to express a left-wing voting intention than individuals who favour other beverage types. These findings indicate that some beverage preferences may operate as signals of political identity.

Support for H2 but not for H1 presents an interesting implication about the nature of taste in the British right. The findings suggest that beverage preference may be more politically meaningful when it is culturally perceived as a marker of respectability, status, and tradition than when it reflects more accessible or mass-market forms of taste. This is consistent with two expectations made previously: first, that the British right comprises both status-oriented voters and more populist voters; and second, that social status is associated with taste-oriented consumption¹⁰. The satisfaction of these theoretical expectations might suggest that traditional conservatives are more concerned with taste than populist conservatives. This interpretation is also consistent with the earlier assertion that the British right is more socially and culturally heterogeneous than the left. However, because this analysis does not directly measure these subgroups as distinct voter categories, this interpretation cannot be treated as conclusive.

Through its principal finding and theoretical development, this paper has made three main contributions to the literature: first, it has extended lifestyle-politics research through a novel examination of alcoholic beverage preferences as mediums of political expression, with empirical support for one hypothesis; second, it has developed a novel mechanism to explain the relationship between taste and political expression by combining Bourdieu's theory of

¹⁰ This is also consistent with Bourdieu's characterisation of 'legitimate taste' (p.16, 1984), meaning the sophisticated tastes of the upper classes.

socially structured taste with Tajfel & Turner's social categorisation theory; and third, it has shown that while political meaning may not inundate the domain of alcoholic beverage preference generally, there is evidence to suggest that it can be transmitted by legitimate taste driven consumption.

Overall, this paper has shown that some alcoholic beverages can behave as plausible signals of voting intention. As politics becomes increasingly polarised and fragmented, political identity is not only expressed at the ballot box, but also through everyday manifestations of taste and consumption. Studying the mundane as mediums of taste and political expression may help us to understand how and why political divisions become embedded in and reproduced by ordinary social life. Further research is therefore important to unpack this phenomenon further. Scholars interested in such work might consider research with a survey that is more purpose-built for this kind of research, whereby a greater range of options are provided, with the option to rank preferences. Similar work may also consider predicting support for the Conservative Party and Reform UK separately, to help separate the populist right and traditional right even further, which may grant richer and more detailed findings. There may also be utility in researching entirely different mediums of taste where similar mechanisms may apply, such as clothing, artworks, or architecture.

In an era of increasingly aggressive and socially divisive political polarisation, understanding how the mundane features of everyday life become intertwined with political identity and markers of division becomes particularly important.